There's one more reason the year 2006 cannot be forgotten: the Pakistan–England Test match at The Oval. Test matches between the two countries have always been controversial, and here we were in the middle of a four-match series in the peak of English summer. We were optimistic going into the tour – England had won the Ashes in 2005 but were reeling from a captaincy crisis prior to our series. Pakistan, meanwhile, was in top form. We had managed to win four of our last eight Tests – England, India (both at home) and Sri Lanka (away) – and lost none.

Importantly, the Pakistan team had embraced spirituality in a big way as part of our mental preparation for each game. Inzi, our captain, had already established himself as a leader. He had a good working relationship with Bob Woolmer. The team's collective imagination was centred around Islam, which Inzi bhai had made the centrepiece of his style of leadership. Yousuf Youhana was now Mohammad Yousuf. I had let my beard grow too, just like Inzi. We found unity in piety and prayed regularly. It reflected in our discipline, if not our performance. Some thought that it was a contentious path to take, but I think that just like some people push for a healthy work–life balance, we went through our own version of it – a cricket–spirituality balance. Sure, my other leaders in the past – Wasim, Waqar, Ramiz – had never been openly devout practitioners of the faith, but they were all good men. And here was Inzi, also a good man, in his own way.

Back to England, the usually scandal-prone summer tour was going rather well. Yousuf was the best batsman in our side, stylish and solid; Younis Khan was firing on all cylinders; Inzi bhai was getting consistent 50s. The rest of us were mediocre but still battle-ready. The only thing which was really hampering our squad was injuries. Our two strike bowlers, Shoaib Akhtar and Mohammad Asif, were out of the team due to various injuries. Neither Mohammad Sami nor Umar Gul nor Danish Kaneria were doing the job for us on the field.

We were trailing the four-match series 2–0. There had been some bad umpiring decisions in the third Test at Headingley already, and Inzi wasn't happy with both umpires officiating in the previous match: Darrel Hair and Billy Doctrove. Hair had a reputation for having an attitude problem towards Asian players. The PCB chairman at the time, Shehryar Khan, was considering putting in a formal request to the ICC to keep him away from all forthcoming Pakistan matches.

As for the contentious bit, everybody knows what happened. We walked away from that Test match thanks to an allegation by Hair – backed by Doctrove – that Pakistan's bowlers had tampered with the ball. As penalty, England was rewarded five runs.

We were stunned but continued playing. However, during the tea break, the senior players in the team backed Inzi and decided that they would not return to the field. To me, the umpires' behaviour was incomprehensible. But Inzi was affected on another level and was seething. The PCB officials couldn't convince him to return to the middle. Hair declared the match forfeited and awarded it to England. Eventually, we managed to overturn the decision at the ICC hearing, declaring the match as 'abandoned'. But later, the ICC reversed its own decision. A couple of months later, Hair was dishonoured and sacked anyway. He was a hateful racist. The end.

By the way, Hair stands disgraced now. In October 2017, he was caught stealing cash from a liquor store where he worked, in Australia.

In retrospect, there were a lot of alternative ways to deal with the situation on the ground. The Pakistan team could have walked off the field, like they do in Parliament, and returned. We could have talked to the match referee later and requested him to intervene. We could have gone to the